02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | DESK REFERENCE

Ladder of Inference: Self-Check

Work through these questions before you decide or ask for a decision.

Step	Question
1. Observe facts	What actually happened?
2. Select information	What did I pay attention to, and what did I skip?
3. Add meaning	What do I think this means?
4. Make assumptions	What am I taking for granted?
5. Draw conclusions	What have I concluded?
6. Form beliefs	What do I now believe is true?
7. Take action	What am I about to do?

Spot the assumption

Fact	Assumption	Better question
The reply said, "Please send your recommendation."	"They've already decided. This is a waste of time."	"What decision is this for, and what should I include?"

Before you decide or escalate

Be clear about the decision. Look up the current policy and who has the authority. Ask the one question that would settle the missing fact. If the answer changes things, change your conclusion.

What I know for sure: _____

What I'm assuming: _____

What I'll ask, and next step: _____

> **Safety first**
> If there's a safety concern or an immediate risk to services, use the urgent process now. Skip this worksheet.

Based on: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: Watch the TED-Ed lesson